

Word family: **middle / middles / middlemost / mid-**

Base word: middle

Plural: middles

Related forms: middlemost, mid-

Part of speech: noun (名詞) / adjective (形容詞) / adverb-like positional use (位置性用法)

Your sentence:

> “However, in the **middle** of the trip, a large sea turtle appeared...”

Meaning in this passage

Here, **middle** means the **central point or period between the beginning and the end of something**.

繁體中文： ** **某件事情由開始到結束之間的中央部分 / 中段**

中文翻譯：

> “...in the **middle** of the trip...”

「.....在行程進行到**中段 / 一半左右**時.....」

Here:

in the middle of the trip = 在旅程 / 行程進行到中間階段時

1. **middle = central part/point (位置) — 中間 ; 中央部分**

This is the central spatial meaning.

Meaning: The part or point that is approximately equally distant from two ends, sides, or edges.

Practice 1

> “There was a table in the **middle** of the room.”

「房間**中央**有一張桌子。」

Practice 2

> “She stood in the **middle** of the road.”

「她站在道路**中間**。」

****middle = 位於兩端、兩邊或外圍之間的中央位置 / 部分****

Common:

- * middle of the room
- * middle of the road
- * middle seat
- * middle section

2. ****middle = intermediate stage/time (時間 / 過程) — 中段 ; 中期****

This is the meaning used in your passage.

****Meaning:**** The stage or period between the beginning and the end of an event, process, trip, story, etc.

Practice 3 — Original

> “In the ****middle**** of the trip, a sea turtle appeared.”

「在行程進行到****中段****時，一隻海龜出現了。」

Practice 4

> “I woke up in the ****middle**** of the night.”

「我在****半夜 / 夜深中段****醒來。」

Practice 5

> “The story becomes more exciting in the ****middle****.”

「故事到了****中段****變得更精彩。」

****middle = 一件事情由開始到結束之間的中間階段****

For strict counting, I would merge spatial and temporal ****middle**** under one broader concept:

> ****the central part between two ends****

The Golden Manual says not to split merely because one example is physical and another is

temporal if the same mental concept still works.

3. **middle = intermediate in rank/size/age (中等 / 中間層級) — 中等的 ; 中間的**

As an adjective, **middle** can describe something between higher/lower, older/younger, larger/smaller, etc.

Practice 6

> “She is the **middle** child in the family.”

「她是家中的**中間排行孩子**。」

Practice 7

> “The company targets the **middle** market.”

「公司針對**中端市場**。」

middle = 在等級、大小、年齡、地位等方面處於兩端之間的

This is a related positional sense.

4. **middle = middle-class/social/economic level (社會 / 經濟) — 中產的 ; 中等階層的**

In compounds, **middle** often refers to an intermediate social or economic group.

Practice 8

> “The area is popular with **middle-class** families.”

「這個地區很受**中產家庭**歡迎。」

Practice 9

> “They are from a **middle-income** household.”

「他們來自一個**中等收入**家庭。」

This is best treated as a compound/domain extension of Meaning 3, not a separate bare-word meaning.

5. ****the middle = central group/position between extremes (立場 / 選擇) — 中間立場；折衷位置****

****Middle**** can figuratively mean a position between two extremes.

Practice 10

> “His view lies somewhere in the ****middle****.”

「他的觀點介乎兩個極端之間，處於****中間立場****。」

Practice 11

> “We need to find a ****middle**** position.”

「我們需要找到一個****折衷 / 中間位置****。」

****middle = 兩種極端、立場或選擇之間的中間位置****

For strict counting, I would merge this with the broader positional sense.

6. ****middle = waist/central body area (身體) — 腰部；身體中段****

In informal use, ****middle**** can mean the central part of the body.

Practice 12

> “He put his hands around his ****middle****.”

「他把雙手放在自己的****腰腹部****。」

Practice 13

> “The belt felt tight around her ****middle****.”

「腰帶在她的****腰部****很緊。」

****middle = 人體軀幹中間部分，通常指腰腹附近****

This is a contextual extension of the central-part sense.

Useful expression: ****in the middle of something — 正在……當中****

This can also mean being actively occupied with something.

Practice 14

> “I’m in the ****middle of**** cooking.”

「我正在****煮飯當中****。」

Practice 15

> “She called while I was in the ****middle of**** a meeting.”

「她打電話來時，我正在****開會中****。」

****in the middle of = 某件事情正在進行中，尚未完成****

This belongs to the temporal/process sense.

Useful expression: ****middle of nowhere — 荒郊野外；偏僻地方****

Practice 16

> “The cabin was in the ****middle of nowhere****.”

「那間小屋位於****荒郊野外 / 非常偏僻的地方****。」

****middle of nowhere = 非常偏遠、附近幾乎沒有建築或人的地方****

This is idiomatic rather than a new core meaning.

Important distinction: ****middle vs centre****

****middle****

usually means the part between two ends or extremes.

****centre****

means the exact or approximate central point.

> middle of the road

= 道路中間

> centre of the circle

= 圓心 / 圓中央

In many everyday contexts they overlap, but **centre** often sounds more geometrically precise.

Important distinction: **middle** vs **half**

middle

= the central section or point

half

= one of two equal parts

> middle of the journey

does not necessarily mean exactly:

> halfway

It can mean roughly around the central stage.

This matters in your sentence: **in the middle of the trip** does not require mathematical 50%.

Important distinction: **middle** vs **mid-**

middle

is a full independent word:

> middle of the year

mid-

is a combining form:

> mid-year
> mid-July
> mid-1990s

Both express central/intermediate position or time, but their grammar differs.

Important distinction: **middle** vs **medium**

middle

describes position between extremes.

medium

often describes size, degree, or level.

> middle seat

= 中間座位

> medium size

= 中碼

Not interchangeable.

Family-extension note

The practical modern family is relatively small:

* **middle**

* **middles**

* **middlemost**

* **mid-**

Useful constructions include:

* middle of the room
* middle of the trip
* middle child
* middle class

- * middle income
- * in the middle of doing something
- * middle of nowhere

The Golden Manual says small families should remain small while common constructions and figurative extensions are still checked.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
-----	-----
middle — central position	位於兩端、兩邊或外圍之間的中央部分 / 位置
middle — central stage/time	一事情由開始到結束之間的中間階段
middle — intermediate level/rank	在大小、年齡、等級、地位等方面處於兩端之間的
middle — body area	人體軀幹的中間部分，通常指腰腹附近
in the middle of	某件事情正在進行中；或處於其中間階段
middle of nowhere	非常偏遠、荒涼、附近幾乎沒有人的地方

For your original sentence

> “However, in the ****middle**** of the trip, a large sea turtle appeared...”

The exact meaning is:

****middle = 行程由開始到結束之間的中段****

So:

> ****in the middle of the trip****

= ****在行程進行到中間階段時****

For your database, I would count ****3 genuinely useful core meanings**** for ****middle****:

1. ****central part or position between two ends****
2. ****central stage/time between beginning and end****
3. ****intermediate rank, level, size, age, or social/economic position****

I would keep ****middle of the body**** under #1, merge figurative middle positions under #3, and treat ****in the middle of**** and ****middle of nowhere**** as constructional/idiomatic extensions rather than inflate the core count.